Chapter 15 – The British East India Company

The 15th and 16th centuries were known to Europe as the Age of Discovery. Explorers traveled by ship, on horseback, and on foot to find new, distant lands and see what they had to offer. For wealthy nations like England, the world was expanding, and one of the most exciting discoveries was that of exotic, far-away India. Decorated with sparkling jewels and full of aromatic, exotic spices that tickled and delighted the taste buds, India was right where commercial traders from the West wanted to be. It was so popular, in fact, that Christopher Columbus accidentally discovered the New World in his haste to find a shortcut. For the English, a nation whose middle class was growing and able to indulge just a little bit more than it had been in previous centuries, cultivating a lasting relationship with India seemed the logical thing to do.

India and Great Britain were connected by trade as early as the 16th century, during the rule of England's Queen Elizabeth I. British merchants sailed east in search of Indian and Chinese ports after the Portuguese settlements had been in place for years, but their journeys did not go unrewarded. Just as Portugal, China, Afghanistan, and many others had found veritable fortunes in the form of merchant and factory agreements with India, so too did England stake a claim that would change the futures of both countries.

It was especially pertinent for England during that time to expand its empire, since Spain and Portugal were busy splitting up the New World for themselves. In Europe, England was a small but respectable kingdom; as neighboring European nations created worldwide empires, however, England could have easily been swallowed up by those very same colonial forces. To establish herself among the most important and wealthiest of her peers, Queen Elizabeth I looked not primarily to the west but to the east. Whereas the Americas clearly had an immense store of gold that was now flowing into Spain, India had a variety of functional resources that included silk, cotton, fabric dyes, salt, tea, gunpowder, and opium.

On December 31st, 1600, the queen granted a royal charter to the newly founded East India Company (EIC), giving it the funds and internal structure she personally believed would benefit her kingdom the most. To facilitate business between the two countries and halt the skirmishes between the EIC and other trade companies, King James I (Elizabeth's successor in 1603) made an agreement with the Mughal Emperor Jahangir